

4.1 Stereo, 7.1 And More

Sound systems and speakers have come a long way from the simple phonogram. Today you have a variety of systems to choose from, be it satellite speakers placed in the corner of your room and sub-woofer at the foot of your TV stand, or the elaborate multiple speaker setup that can reproduce each little sound. So moral of the story is that the more the number of satellite speakers you have the better it is, right? Wrong! Though a multiple-satellite-speaker setup will give you richer sound compared to simple stereo speakers, for a true theatre experience it is also important to have a good sound format.

DTS (Digital Theatre Surround) and Dolby Digital are two of the most commonly used sound formats across the world. DTS is a multi-channel surround-sound format used for commercial and consumer applications, that is, in movie halls and home theatre systems. It is primarily used for in-movie sound, both on film and on DVD. The basic and most common version of the format is a 5.1 channel system, supporting five primary speakers and a sub-woofer. However, newer variants currently available support up to nine primary audio channels.

DTS' main competitors are Dolby Digital and SDDS (Sony Digital Dynamic Sound), although only Dolby Digital and DTS are used on DVDs and implemented in home theatre hardware.

Once you have the sound format figured out, it's all about the speaker setup. The most commonly used setup is 5.1. This requires a left, centre and right front speakers, left and right surround speakers, and a subwoofer that produces the bass from all the main channels - or which may only do so for those speakers incapable of doing so. 6.1 channel sound is similar to 5.1, but there is an added centre-rear channel. The number of speakers in a setup can thus be increased for richer sound quality.

It is important to note that the sound channels offered to the speakers may be original, individual channels - or they may decode additional channels from the surround channels.